

Northwestern - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Adequate Power 4 / bowl-bubble quality with a defense that should remain the stronger side, but the ceiling is constrained by a new starting QB, two NFL-drafted OL departures and one of the nation's hardest schedules.
Preseason consensus	SP+ No. 50 (+5.1) · AP unranked, zero votes
Returning production	62% - No. 26 overall · Off. 65% - No. 24 · Def. 58% - No. 46
Primer power rating	+5.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.3 wins · likely 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar underlying quality with a different shape - More offensive upside, less OL/defensive continuity, and a schedule likely to worsen the record.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: OC Chip Kelly now has Michigan State transfer QB Aidan Chiles as the named starter and must create more explosiveness around RB Caleb Komolafe and WR Griffin Wilde.

Bottom line: Northwestern has enough defense to compete, but Aidan Chiles still must prove the quarterback upgrade, the OL is rebuilding and SP+ SOS No. 6 makes this a bowl-bubble team needing a meaningful offensive jump.

Beats expectations if: QB Aidan Chiles improves explosiveness, C Jackson Carsello anchors the rebuilt OL, and DC Tim McGarigle improves defensive success rate/havoc despite front-seven losses.

Disappoints if: QB Aidan Chiles does not stabilize the offense, explosiveness stays low, and losses of EDGE Aidan Hubbard, LB Mac Uihlein, CB Fred Davis II and DE Anto Saka expose the defense.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Aidan Chiles has been named Northwestern's starting quarterback after winning the preseason competition.
- 2 ? Play-caller:** Chip Kelly is the new OC, but the exact 2026 offensive game-day play caller remains unresolved.
- 3 2025 baseline:** The defense was No.23 in scoring and No.31 in total yards in 2025, but advanced down-to-down signals were shakier: success rate allowed No.106 and havoc created No.88.
- 4 NFL departures:** OT Caleb Tiernan (Round 3) and G Evan Beerntsen (Round 7) are both NFL draft departures from the 2025 offensive line.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No.6, with road games at Indiana, Oregon and Ohio State plus Penn State and Iowa at home.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	7-6 (4-5 Big Ten)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	23.4 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	346.1 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	160.2 YPG · 4.6 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	6.39 YPA · 17 TD / 13 INT	● Poor
Third downs	43.4%	● Good / above average
Scoring defense	19.8 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	329.8 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	136.2 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	193.5 YPG · 7.25 YPA · 13 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Northwestern won with a defense-first profile: scoring defense No.23 and total defense No.31 versus scoring offense No.98 and total offense No.98. The offense’s best conventional signal was third-down conversion at No.36, while pass efficiency was No.110.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-1.42 · No. 74	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.026 · No. 57	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	42.9% · No. 64	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	10.5% · No. 109	● Poor
Havoc allowed	16.3% · No. 86	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+1.38 · No. 54	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.036 · No. 48	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	44.4% · No. 106	● Poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.5% · No. 82	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	14.5% · No. 88	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: Northwestern's offense was less poor than its scoring/yardage ranks but lacked explosiveness and pass efficiency. The defense's strong traditional results masked only average adjusted/EPA play and poor success-rate/havoc marks.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	David Braun - returning	● ↔ David Braun's return keeps the program structure stable through a major offensive staff change.
OC	◆ Chip Kelly - new from Las Vegas Raiders OC	● ↑ New role creates upside with normal transition risk
DC / play-caller	Tim McGarigle - returning	● ↔ Tim McGarigle returns as defensive play-caller, preserving continuity on that side of the ball.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Aidan Chiles	Michigan State	● ↔ Prominent arrival who has won the starting job; consistency and explosiveness remain the evaluation questions.
◆ QB Nicco Marchiol	West Virginia	● ↔ Experienced starter candidate returning from a 2025 foot injury.
◆ OL Grant Seagren	Oklahoma State	● ↔ Projected tackle candidate on a line replacing two NFL draftees.

Out	To	Loss
QB Preston Stone	Eligibility/graduation; no destination established	● ↔ The 13-game 2025 starter departs; the new winner and level remain unresolved.
OT Caleb Tiernan	NFL (Minnesota), Round 3, No. 97	● ↓ Round-3 NFL departure removes a proven starting tackle.
G Evan Beerntsen	NFL (Baltimore), Round 7, No. 253	● ↓ 13-game starting guard and Round-7 draft departure compounds OL transition.
TE Lawson Albright	Eligibility/graduation; no destination established	● ↓ Nine-start 2025 TE leaves a position with little established certainty.

Offensive net: ● ↔ **Roughly similar**, with more QB ceiling but meaningful OL/TE uncertainty.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Kobie McKinzie	Oklahoma	● ↑ Expected starter with LB Braydon Brus after LB Mac Uihlein's departure.
◆ DL Dominic Kirks	Ohio State	● ↔ Material front addition, though his exact role remains unsettled.

Out	To	Loss
EDGE Aidan Hubbard	NFL (Seattle), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 11-start, 10-TFL, 7.5-sack 2025 edge leaves as a UDFA signing.
LB Mac Uihlein	Chicago Bears rookie minicamp tryout	● ↓ The 2025 leading tackler departs; the Bears connection is a tryout only.
CB Fred Davis II	NFL (Washington), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material 2025 secondary contributor departs for an NFL opportunity.
DE Anto Saka	Texas A&M	● ↓ Meaningful front transfer departure adds to the pass-rush rebuild.

Defensive net: ● ↓ **Slight downgrade** unless LB Kobie McKinzie and the transfer front quickly replace high-leverage production.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Personnel-adaptive OC Chip Kelly offense now led by named starter QB Aidan Chiles.	RB Caleb Komolafe, WR Griffin Wilde and C Jackson Carsello provide clear anchors.	Chiles' consistency, two drafted OL losses and poor 2025 explosiveness/pass efficiency.
Defense	DC Tim McGarigle continuity around a veteran spine but meaningful turnover.	S Robert Fitzgerald, LB Braydon Brus and LB Kobie McKinzie anchor the middle.	Poor 2025 success-rate/havoc metrics plus major pass-rush/tackling losses.
Special teams	Transfer kicker replacing K Jack Olsen.	K Jackson Kleather has Lou Groza recognition and SP+ ranks the unit No. 29.	New placekicker role remains a projection.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	QB Aidan Chiles has won the job; his ability to raise efficiency and explosiveness now drives the grade.
RB	● B–	● ↔	Medium	RB Caleb Komolafe is the clearest returning skill anchor in the new offense.
WR	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	WR Griffin Wilde is the best-supported primary target for an offense needing more explosiveness.
TE	● C	● ↓	Low	TE Lawson Albright’s departure leaves a thin, unsettled role picture.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	C Jackson Carsello anchors a line replacing two NFL-drafted starters.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	EDGE Aidan Hubbard and DE Anto Saka depart, forcing the front to replace pass-rush production.
LB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Braydon Brus anchors the group after an 81-tackle 2025 season.
Secondary	● B	● ↓	Medium	S Robert Fitzgerald returns after 115 tackles, but the secondary loses veteran contributors.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium	K Jackson Kleather is the recognized replacement for K Jack Olsen.
Coaching	● B+	● ↑	Medium	OC Chip Kelly adds upside while HC David Braun and DC Tim McGarigle preserve continuity.
Overall	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	Bowl-bubble quality with a defense-first floor; Aidan Chiles’ performance and a rebuilt OL constrain the ceiling.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Aidan Chiles (TR: Michigan State)	QB	● High-upside named starter	-	Won the starting job; his development could materially change the offense’s ceiling.
◆ Nicco Marchiol (TR: West Virginia)	QB	● Experienced reserve / competition depth	-	Brings starting experience after finishing behind Aidan Chiles in the QB1 competition.
Caleb Komolafe	RB	● Solid Power 4 lead-back projection	Maxwell Award	Clearest returning skill anchor in the new offense.
Griffin Wilde	WR	● High-end conference starter / primary-target candidate	Biletnikoff Award	Best-supported primary-target projection for an offense needing explosiveness.
Jackson Carsello	C	● Solid Power 4 starter / OL anchor	Rimington Trophy	Returning center on a line replacing two NFL-drafted starters.
Braydon Brus	LB	● High-end conference starter / defensive anchor	-	Key continuity piece after LB Mac Uihlein departs.
◆ Kobie McKinzie (TR: Oklahoma)	LB	● High-upside major-role linebacker	-	Important transfer replacement alongside LB Braydon Brus.
Robert Fitzgerald	S	● High-end conference starter / defensive centerpiece	Bednarik Award	The most secure high-leverage returning defensive role.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Very difficult; the Wildcats can be an improved or stable team and still struggle to reach six wins.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · SP+ SOS No. 6
Hardest stretch	at Oregon → Iowa → at Ohio State → at Minnesota → Illinois
Swing games	Colorado, at Michigan State, Rutgers, at Minnesota, Illinois
Advantage	A Week 2 bye follows South Dakota State, and Ball State breaks up the schedule before the final Big Ten run.
Expected	5.3 wins · likely 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 7-5

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Avoid overrating either the 7-6 record/No. 23 scoring defense or the upside of the new offense before Aidan Chiles proves he can raise the efficiency ceiling.
Back them when	Aidan Chiles has stabilized the offense and Northwestern is catching points against comparable teams that cannot stress the defense with sustained explosiveness.
Fade/pass when	The offense is priced as fixed, or elite offenses can exploit a defense replacing major front-seven and CB production.
Key monitor	Aidan Chiles' early efficiency, exact offensive caller, final OL, front-seven disruption, health of defensive anchors
Week 1 baseline	vs. South Dakota State: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Northwestern –12.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Northwestern has a credible defensive core and more theoretical offensive upside under OC Chip Kelly, with transfer QB Aidan Chiles now named the starter while the OL replaces two drafted starters. The 2025 defense was also less dominant down to down than its scoring rank suggests.

SP+ SOS No. 6 keeps the Wildcats on the bowl bubble even if team quality holds steady. Five wins is the likeliest result; six or seven requires Chiles to be the clear QB answer and a real jump in offensive explosiveness.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching staff](#) · [OC Kelly](#) · [DC McGarigle](#) · [media day](#) · [QB competition](#) · [NFL departure](#) · [NFL departure 2](#) · [QB1 update](#)

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